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Stephen

The first Christian martyr, who died praying for those who killed him.

Stephen first appears as one of seven men chosen to make sure the widows of the Jerusalem church were fed fairly. He was known as a man "full of faith and of the Holy Ghost." But he did far more than serve tables. He did wonders among the people and argued so wisely that his opponents could not answer him. Brought before the council on false charges, he gave the longest speech in Acts, retelling Israel's story from Abraham to Solomon. When he said he saw Jesus standing at God's right hand, the crowd stoned him. He died praying for his killers. A young man named Saul watched, and the church was scattered far beyond Jerusalem.

At a glance

Name	Greek <i>Stephanos</i> , "crown" or "wreath"
Family	Not given
Role	One of the seven chosen to serve the widows (Acts 6:3–5)
When	Died c. AD 33–35
Key places	Jerusalem
Key people	The twelve apostles; Philip the evangelist and the other five; the high priest; Saul (Paul)
Main passages	Acts 6:1–8:2; 11:19; 22:20
Known as	The first Christian to die for his faith

"And they stoned Stephen, calling upon God, and saying, Lord Jesus, receive my spirit."

Acts 7:59, KJV

The life of Stephen

Dates are approximate (AD). Acts gives no year for Stephen's death. Most place it a few years after the resurrection, c. AD 33–35.

Early church <i>Jerusalem</i>	● Chosen as one of the seven Greek-speaking believers complain that their widows are overlooked in the daily food. The apostles ask the church to choose seven trusted men, and Stephen is named first. <i>Acts 6:1–6</i>
Jerusalem	● Wonders and wisdom Stephen, "full of faith and power," does great wonders among the people. Men from several synagogues argue with him, but they cannot resist the wisdom and Spirit with which he speaks. <i>Acts 6:8–10</i>
Before the council	● False charges His opponents stir up the people and bring false witnesses. They claim he speaks against the temple and the law. The council sees his face "as it had been the face of an angel." <i>Acts 6:11–15</i>
Before the council	● The great speech Stephen retells Israel's history: Abraham, Joseph, Moses, the tabernacle and the temple. He shows that Israel often rejected the ones God sent, and he charges his hearers with doing the same. <i>Acts 7:1–53</i>
c. AD 33–35 <i>Outside the city</i>	● Stoned Stephen sees the heavens opened and Jesus standing at God's right hand. The crowd drags him out and stones him. He prays for them and "fell asleep." <i>Acts 7:54–60</i>
After his death	● Buried and mourned Devout men bury Stephen with great lamentation. A great persecution breaks out, and believers scatter, preaching the word wherever they go. <i>Acts 8:1–4; 11:19</i>

Key activities

Stephen's speech in Acts 7 sometimes differs in small details from Genesis, such as where Abraham's call came and the numbers in Jacob's family. Most readers see Stephen following the Greek Old Testament or summarising freely.

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- 1 Served the widows.** He was chosen to oversee the daily distribution of food, so the apostles could give themselves to prayer and the word. *Acts 6:2-6*

 - 2 Did great wonders.** "Stephen, full of faith and power, did great wonders and miracles among the people." *Acts 6:8*

 - 3 Spoke with wisdom.** His opponents "were not able to resist the wisdom and the spirit by which he spake." *Acts 6:10*

 - 4 Retold Israel's story.** He traced God's work from Abraham to Solomon and taught that "the most High dwelleth not in temples made with hands." *Acts 7:2-50*

 - 5 Spoke hard truth.** He called his hearers "stiffnecked and uncircumcised in heart and ears." *Acts 7:51-53*

 - 6 Saw Jesus in glory.** "Behold, I see the heavens opened, and the Son of man standing on the right hand of God." *Acts 7:55-56*

 - 7 Forgave his killers.** He kneeled and cried, "Lord, lay not this sin to their charge." *Acts 7:60*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links. "Protomartyr" is a title from later tradition.

Old Testament

Genesis 12 – Exodus 32; 1 Kings 6–8	The history his speech retells
Amos 5:25–27; Isaiah 66:1–2	Prophets he quotes (Acts 7:42–43, 49–50)
Echo: 2 Chronicles 24:20–22	Zechariah stoned for speaking God's word

New Testament

Acts 6:1–8:2	The main account
Acts 8:1; 22:20	Saul consented and kept the killers' clothes
Acts 11:19	The scattering spreads the gospel to Antioch
Echo: Luke 23:34, 46	Jesus' dying prayers, mirrored by Stephen's
Echo: Revelation 2:10	The "crown of life," often linked with his name

For discussion

- Observe:* What words does Acts use to describe Stephen's character (Acts 6:3, 5, 8, 10)?
- Understand:* Stephen was chosen to hand out food, yet became a great witness. What does that say about "small" jobs?
- Apply:* Stephen prayed for those hurting him. Who is hard for you to forgive, and how could you pray for them?
- Apply:* Where have you seen God bring good out of a painful loss?